

Microsoft joins OpenChain project as platinum member

Microsoft has joined the OpenChain project as a platinum member to help define standards for open source software compliance. Microsoft is the latest addition to the list of OpenChain members that include Uber, Google and Facebook, which joined the project last month.

As a platinum member, a representative from Microsoft will join the OpenChain governing board. Other platinum members of the OpenChain project include Adobe, ARM Holdings, Cisco, Comcast, Facebook, GitHub, Google, Harman International, Hitachi, Qualcomm, Siemens, Sony, Toshiba, Toyota, Uber and Western Digital.



“Trust is key to open source, and compliance with open source licences is an important part of building that trust,” David Rudin, assistant general counsel, Microsoft, said in a blog post.

Rudin added, “By joining the OpenChain project, we look forward to working alongside the community to define compliance standards that help build confidence in the open source ecosystem and supply chain.”

The OpenChain project builds trust in open source by making its licence compliance simpler and more consistent.

OpenChain provides a specification as well as the overarching processes, policies and training that companies need in order to be successful in managing open source licence compliance. Hence the process becomes more efficient, understandable and predictable for participants of the software supply chain.

Microsoft is also working with the Linux Foundation’s TODO Group, which is an open group of companies that collaborate to create practices, tools and other ways for running open source programs. The company also joined the Open Invention Network (OIN) last year in October and made its entire patent portfolio available to OIN members.

OpenChain general manager Shane Coughlan wrote in a blog post, “We’re thrilled that Microsoft has joined the project and welcome its expertise. Microsoft is a strong addition not only in terms of open source but also in standardisation. The company’s membership provides great balance to our community of enterprise, cloud, automotive and silicon companies, allowing us to ensure the standard is suitable for any sized company across any industry.”

Mozilla to release Firefox 66 with the ‘autoplay blocking’ feature

Mozilla, the maker of the open source browser Firefox, is adding a new feature to the search engine to block audible audio and video playbacks, by default.

The ‘autoplay blocking’ feature will be a part of Firefox 66, which is scheduled for general release in March 2019.

“We know that unsolicited volume can be a great source of distraction and frustration for users of the Web. So, we are making changes to how Firefox handles playing media with sound,” Mozilla software engineer Chris Pearce wrote in a blog post.

“Any playback that happens before the user has interacted with a page via a mouse click, printable key press, or touch event, is deemed to be autoplay and will be blocked if it is potentially audible,” Pearce said.

Users can make their own whitelist of sites from which they prefer the audible autoplay of audio and video to be allowed.

When ‘Firefox for Desktop’ blocks autoplay audio or video, an icon appears in the URL bar. Users can click on the icon to access the site’s information panel, from where they can change the ‘Autoplay sound’ permission for that site from the default setting of ‘Block’ to ‘Allow’. Firefox will then allow that site to autoplay audibly.

“We are also allowing sites to autoplay audibly if the user has previously granted them camera or microphone permission, so that sites which have explicit user permission continue to work as they do today,” Pearce said.

Mention may be made that Google, Microsoft and Apple have also added provisions to limit and mute autoplaying media on Chrome, Edge and Safari browsers, respectively.